

The Green Journal of Hesper

*Nine chapters from an orbital farm whose only plant speaks in
leaves*

scriptaWorlds · ALA

2026

For the ones whose names were cut out at the binding.

Table of contents

Preface	4
Until It Stops Shaking	6
What the Officer Wrote	13
The Name He Did Not Say	21
The Shape Without a Word	30
The Line That Could Not Fail	39
The One Who Remembers	46
What the Page Cost	54
What the Wall Stopped Asking	61
The Hand That Has to Say It	69
Afterword	77

Preface

Hesper is a farm: a root ring, a work ring and a low ring strung on a spine in orbit, forty-one people, stores that come up from the surface on manifests, and one plant.

That plant fills the root wall and it holds the station's air. It has no voice. It speaks with its leaves, which bend into drawn shapes, and the shapes are read by a child — the Reader — because a child reads a shape whole, while an adult reads the letters he was taught and stops there.

Whatever the plant is read as asking for is granted within three days, and the request is written into the green journal, one dated line in the officer's hand. A line that is not kept costs the hand that wrote it a tooth, then a finger, then an eye. There has never been a fourth day, so nobody on Hesper knows what follows an eye, and the farm says so the way it says the air pressure.

This book is nine chapters of that arithmetic. It opens on a third morning, with three arms lying unbandaged in the infirmary because the plant has not stopped shaking, and it follows what a small crew does when the only instrument it has for its own survival is a page of drawn shapes and a child who can read them and cannot read anything else.

The Green Journal of Hesper is not a story about a monster in the soil, and it is not a story about a rebellion. It is about a farm that must answer something every single day, with water and light and warmth and, sometimes, with blood; about a doctor who keeps a column of numbers on an infirmary wall because that column is the only honest record of what the farm has actually done; about an officer who was punished as a boy and has been careful ever since; about an old man who drew the chart of signs and then stopped reading them; about an engineer who counts the register's holes; and about a mother who has worked the second shift for nine years so as not to stand under the flower.

What the book is after is narrower than a war and harder than one. It asks what a request means when the one who makes it cannot be asked back; what a rule is worth when nothing enforces it except the habit of the people who keep it; and what a farm owes the children it has already spent. Every chapter here is a consequence of a single law, stated at the front of the story and never broken: the plant asks, the farm answers, and the answer is measured in what the farm can see.

Read it the way the crew reads its own wall. The days are dated, the readings are in the doctor's hand, and the two things that never stop running — the count in the book and the column on the wall — will tell you where you are.

Until It Stops Shaking

Three arms lay in Meren's infirmary, none of them bandaged, because the plant had not stopped shaking.

The first belonged to the woman from the second shift, who had opened her palm over the roots on the first morning and had held it open since, over a bowl, because the ritual asked for that too. The second belonged to the boy from the water crew, fourteen years old, who had cut himself on the second night without being told, to be useful, and had been praised for it in front of everybody. The third was Meren's own work: on the officer's order, on the second morning, she had opened a hand with her own shears and had regretted it before the blood reached the soil.

All three had bled into the roots. The leaves had gone on trembling.

The trembling was the only answer the plant ever gave, and it carried the whole law of Hesper inside it: a request was met when the shaking stopped. For three days it had not stopped.

Meren tied her hair back and stood where the light was worst, so that she would have to be looked at.

"Nobody cuts today," she said.

She said it to the arms, to the shelf, and to the shears she had not picked up. Then Rusk came in with the green journal under his arm.

He was sixty and had the thinnest blood on the farm. His sleeves were rolled to the elbow, old scars over new ones, and he held his forearms out the way a man holds out a document.

"The third day," he said. "You know what the third day costs."

"I know what your arms cost. If I open you again you will go down at the roots and I will carry you back through the ring in front of everyone."

"I have carried worse."

"You have carried worse *for the plant*. That is the whole of your argument, and it has never once been medicine."

He put the journal on her table and opened it at the last page. Three lines, in his handwriting, one for each morning: *The plant asks for blood*. He wrote them himself, every time, from the chart.

"Say the reading is wrong," he said quietly. "Say it in front of the crew. Then you take the tooth off the woman and put it in your own mouth."

Meren looked at the woman from the second shift, who was not asleep, and who was listening with her eyes closed.

"Three days," Meren said. "Three cuts. Has it ever stopped shaking for longer than it takes to put the shears down?"

"Twice, on the first day. A few minutes." Rusk said it as though it were good news.

"A few minutes is not an answer. That is a bruise. We gave it blood three times and it shook through all three, and tonight the count runs out and somebody pays."

"That is why the third day asks for more."

"And on the fourth day?"

"There has never been a fourth day."

Meren had heard the story of Rusk's ninth year the way everyone on Hesper heard it. He had told the other children about a forest — a thing he had never seen, described to him from a picture in a supply crate — and he had spent a year working the roots in silence for it, with a cloth over his mouth so that the words could not come out. Thirty years and one promotion later he still did not say the word. He said *the place in the picture*. The law had made him careful, and careful had made him officer, and there was no way to argue with a man like that except with the plant itself.

* * *

She found Bea at the root wall with her slate on her knees.

The wall filled the end of the ring: one wall of the plant, taller than the loading doors, with the roots coming out of the soil and down into the floor grates like something reaching for water. Above them the leaves were in slow motion, all of them at once, the way they had been for three days.

Bea was seven. She had held the Reader's post for eleven months, since the child before her had grown too old for it, and she could not read a written word to save her life. Children read the shapes better than adults; that was in the law, and it was also the plain truth of the thing, because an adult looked at a leaf and saw the letters he had been taught, and stopped there.

"Good morning," Meren said, and sat down on the floor beside her, which hurt.

Bea did not look up. She had drawn the same sign on the slate forty times, in chalk: a long stroke with a bend at the end of it.

"Read it to me again."

"Blood."

"Show me where the blood is."

Bea touched the bend at the end of the stroke. "Here. The hook turns back."

"And the dash?"

"What dash?"

Meren took the slate, wiped it with her sleeve, and gave it back. "Draw it as big as you can. As big as the floor."

The girl drew it as big as the floor. The long stroke. The hook at the end, turning back toward the stem. And across the stem, near the bottom, the small bar that she had told Meren about in her second week, the bar that meant *water*, the bar that nobody drew any more.

"The dash is what makes it water," Meren said. "You told me that yourself. In the spring."

Bea looked at the floor, and then at the leaves, and then at the floor again. The leaves had the bar. They had had the bar for three days.

"It is not blood," she said. "It is iron in the water."

"Say it again."

"It is iron. In the water." Her voice did not break, which was the worst part. She had been raised on this farm and she knew exactly what she had just said out loud. "It has the dash. It has the dash and I did not see it because the chart does not have it."

Meren stayed on the floor a moment longer with her hands on her knees, doing the arithmetic of three days: a palm, an arm, her own cut, and the gauze still rolled on the shelf.

"The chart," she said. "Who drew the chart?"

"The Reader before me. He read for eleven years." Bea was crying now, in the way children cry when they have not yet been told whether they are in trouble. "He lost a tooth. He told me the chart was what he got instead of it."

Meren stood up. "Then here is what happens. You are going to read that sign out loud at the roots, in front of Rusk and everyone working the soil. I am going to take the feed line apart while you do it. And if the plant is still shaking at dusk, I open my own hand and Rusk writes whatever he likes in his book."

* * *

The crew came to the root wall the way the crew came when the plant shook: quietly, all of them, in work clothes, nobody sending for anybody.

Rusk brought the journal and opened it at a new page. Bea stood under the leaves with the slate against her chest and read the sign out loud — the long stroke, the hook, and the dash.

"Iron in the water," she said.

Then she read it again, because Meren had told her to, and again: three times, one for each day.

Meren was already down in the feed trench with a wrench, on her knees in water that should have been clear. It was not clear. When she cracked the union at the manifold, what came out was brown, and it came out with grit in it. The valve seat was eaten through in a crescent, and the water had been running through that crescent into the root bed for months.

She had asked for a new seat twice. The manifold had struck it off twice.

"Open the bypass," she called up. "The clean one. All the way."

The brown water went off into the sump. Fresh water came down the line with a different sound, and the crew heard it through the floor.

The leaves held still for a moment. Then they moved — not the long slow tremor of the three days, but small and sideways, like a hand feeling along a wall. Then they stopped.

Nobody spoke. The boy from the water crew said, "Is it done?" and Meren, still in the trench, said, "It is done."

* * *

They bandaged the three arms before the light went.

The woman from the second shift said nothing at all. The boy watched his own hand being wrapped as if it belonged to somebody on the surface. Rusk stood by the journal and touched his jaw, twice, on the side where the tooth would have come from, and did not know that Meren was watching him do it.

Then he wrote in the green journal, at the top of the new page, the sentence that Meren dictated and Bea said out loud first, so that there could be no doubt about whose words they were:

The plant asks for clean water in the roots. Nobody cuts until the child has read the sign at the roots and spoken it.

The old chart came down off the wall. Meren folded it in four and put it in the drawer where she kept the things nobody wanted to look at.

"Nobody holds the bowl for me again, either," Bea said. "When there is cutting."

"There will not be cutting." Meren crouched to her, which hurt. "And that is a promise. Nobody opens a hand on a reading you have not spoken at the roots, in front of witnesses, with your own voice. Not next year, not when you are tall. Write it on your slate if you do not believe me."

Bea wrote it on her slate in chalk, in her round hand, and then drew the sign again underneath, freehand, not from the chart, from the leaves.

She stopped. She looked up at the wall.

"There is another one," she said.

* * *

The leaves above the roots had moved. High up, where the light was thin, a shape had come out that filled six leaves at once, with a stem that bent twice and a hook that turned all the way around.

Bea copied it with her chalk, and then, because she was seven and thorough, she turned the slate around so that the grown-ups could see it.

Rusk looked at it for a long time. Then he took the journal down again and turned it over to the back pages, where the Reader before Bea had written, nine years ago, one sign and one word beside it.

The same sign. The word: *flower*.

"Nine years," he said. "It is coming. The last time it flowered we gave it a name, and we have not said that name out loud since, and we never will."

Bea asked the question before anybody could stop her.

"Whose name this time?"

What the Officer Wrote

By morning the buds had begun to open and the air gauge in the work ring had lost a tenth of a point overnight.

Meren wrote the number on the infirmary wall, where she kept all her numbers in a column, and then walked the ring to the root wall to look at the plant for herself.

The flower sign was still up, high, six leaves wide, the way Bea had copied it onto her slate the night before. Under it, low down where the roots left the soil and went into the floor grates, the leaves had turned into something that had not been there at dusk.

A stroke going up. At the top of the stroke, two hooks turned toward each other, the way two hands turn when they are holding a bowl between them.

Bea sat under it with the slate on her knees and the chalk in her fist, and she was not drawing.

"Read it," Meren said.

"I do not know that one." Bea did not look away from the leaves. "It came in the night. It is not in the chart and it is not on the wall."

"Say what you think it is."

"I do not think. I read." She said it the way a child says a thing that belongs to her. "Bring me a lamp. It is high up and it is dark, and I cannot see the top of it."

Then the leaves began to move, all of them at once, slow and long, and the crew stopped working to listen to it. The floor carried the trembling better than the air did. Three days of it was still in everybody's arms.

* * *

Rusk came in with the green journal under his arm and his sleeves rolled to the elbow, out of habit, the way another man wears a watch.

He stood under the leaves and looked at the small shape for a while, and nobody said anything, because after thirty years of writing the book he was the one who could find any sign in it.

"Long stroke with the bend at the end," he said. "That is blood. And the mark above it, the bar across, that is the one the old Reader drew for a request that comes back." He sounded the line out to himself the way he always did before writing. "It asks for blood again."

"It does not have the bar," Bea said. "It has two hooks."

"It has the stroke and a mark above it."

"Those are not hands."

"Then tell me what they are."

"I told you. I do not know that one yet."

Rusk turned to the crew, and his voice was reasonable, and that was the worst of it.

"Three days ago we did a thing that has never been done on this farm," he said. "A child said a word at this wall and the farm moved water and iron for it, and it was right, and I wrote it in the book in her own words and I would do it again. But today the child stands here and says: I do not know that one. And the book has no page for a Reader who does not know. So somebody has to read, or somebody has to pay, and I am not going to stand in front of a shaking plant with an empty page and tell the crew that the rule is working."

"Write nothing," Meren said. "You have written nothing for three days and nobody has lost anything."

"And the air?" He pointed at the gauge over the door, which was a lie and both of them knew it, because the plant's trembling had never once been about the air until now. "It is flowering, Meren. It will want what it wants, and I have a book to write it in, and I would rather write a wrong line than no line."

"You already wrote a wrong line. It cost three arms."

"I wrote what the chart said, and the chart was wrong, and I have not made that mistake twice." He was quiet for a moment. "I have made it once. This is not the same mistake. This is blood again, and the sign says so, and if the sign is wrong then the plant will tell us the way it always tells us, by not stopping."

He opened the journal at the next clean page and wrote the date, and then, in his square officer's hand:

The plant asks for blood again.

Under it, on the line below, he wrote his own name. Nobody on Hesper had ever written his name in the green journal. The book was the farm's, not a man's.

Meren saw the name and understood what it meant before he said it.

"You have just written yourself a debt," she said. "If nobody cuts in three days, the count runs out on the man who wrote the line."

"Then it runs out on me."

"Rusk."

"I am sixty years old. I have had a tooth longer than the child has had a name." He closed the book. "Write that in your numbers."

* * *

Before noon he went down to the low ring.

Iven had read the leaves for eleven years before Bea, and had lost a tooth for reading one of them wrong, and had not read anything since. He worked the stores now. He was stacking boxes of gauze against the wall, and he did it slowly, and he did not look up.

"I want to know what it is like," Rusk said. "The tooth."

The old man set the box down.

"There is no pain. That is the part the children get wrong. You sleep, and in the morning there is a hole." He touched his jaw with two fingers, at the side, where the gap was, and then took the fingers away. "And the hole does not bleed."

"Nothing else?"

"It was never there. That is the whole of it." He picked the box up again. "You know what I did with the rest of that year? I drew the chart. Eleven years of signs and one word next to each of them, so that nobody on this farm would ever have to read a leaf again. You have been writing out of my chart every morning since. So do not come down here asking me what a tooth is like. Ask me what a chart is like."

* * *

Nobody cut.

The boy from the water crew offered his hand on the second morning, in front of everybody, the way he had offered it in the spring, and Meren stood between him and the shears with the old chart still in the drawer behind her and the promise she had made out loud in front of witnesses.

"The Reader has not spoken," she said. "That is the whole rule. There is no version of it where the arm comes off for a shape nobody has read."

The boy looked at Rusk, who was standing at the wall with his sleeves rolled, and Rusk did not say anything at all, which was answer enough.

The plant kept repeating the small shape. It came every few hours, brighter each time, and each time the hooks at the top of the stroke turned a little further toward each other, and the flower stayed half open like a hand that had forgotten what it was doing. On the second evening the gauge lost another tenth, and Meren wrote that number down too.

On the third morning, Bea asked for a hand lamp.

She did not ask Meren or Rusk. She asked the woman from the second shift, who was closest to the shelf, and she took the lamp and went and stood under the leaves and held it up.

The crown of the root wall was the darkest part of the ring. It always had been. Every leaf up there turned toward the lamp at once — not the whole wall, just the crown, hundreds of them leaning into the little light like people at a door. They followed it when she moved it. When she took it away, they turned back to the dark.

Bea stood there with her arm up and her mouth open, and then she said it, out loud, at the roots, in her own voice, because that was the rule now.

"It is the two bowls over the crown. It wants them filled."

Meren looked up at the crown, and then at the two lamp arms bolted over it with their bowl-shaped shades, which had been dark for two years, since the ballast had been struck off the manifest and had not come back.

"Her reading," she said slowly, "is that the plant wants the lamps."

"Yes."

"Then Rusk has written a line about blood on a morning when the plant was asking for light."

* * *

Rusk took the news the way he took the numbers on the infirmary wall.

"How much light," he said.

"Two arms. The draw is about the water pumps on the low ring, or the heat on the third shift." Meren had already done it in her head, and she did not like it. "We can take the arms off the work ring. They are the same fittings. We cannot run both."

"Then we run the crown."

"The infirmary lamp is one of those arms."

"Then you will work with a hand lamp for a while, and I will sign the draw." He said it before she had finished being sorry about it, and that was the officer in him, and it was also the first time in three days that anybody on Hesper had decided anything. "The plant is asking for the thing the farm can give. I am not going to be the officer who had it in his hand and wrote blood on the page instead."

It took the crew the whole of the third day. The arms came off the brackets in the work ring and went up the spine on a sling, four people to an arm, and the ring went dark behind them shift by shift. Meren took down the infirmary lamp herself and did not say anything about it. Rusk signed the draw in the log and stood under the crown and watched the cable go up the wall.

The arms came on at dusk.

The leaves did not shake. They leaned, the whole crown of them, into the light, and then the small shape went out of the leaves as if it had been wiped off, and something else came up in its place: the flower, properly open, wide, with the stem bent twice and the hook turned all the way around and the middle of it pale and moving.

The trembling stopped. The gauge began to climb while Meren watched it.

Nobody cut anything, and nobody cheered either. They stood in the new light and looked up at the flower, and the woman from the second shift said, out loud, in the quiet, "That is what it wanted."

* * *

Rusk woke on the fourth morning with a hole where his left front tooth had been.

He found it with his tongue before he found it with his hand. There was no pain and no blood, exactly as the old man had said, and the gum had closed over the place as if it had been born that way. He sat on the edge of his bunk for a while. Then he got up, and put on his shirt, and went to the root wall, because that was where the farm was.

The crew was already there. Nobody had sent for anybody. Bea was under the leaves with her slate, and Meren was standing where she could see his face.

He did not tell them. He did not have to. He said good morning, and the word came out with a whistle in it, and every adult in the ring heard the whistle, and the ones who had been on Hesper long enough did the arithmetic of the last three days on their own.

The flower was open, and above it, on the leaves, a new shape was coming up slowly, the way a hand comes up out of water: a stem bent twice, which was the flower sign, and under it a long stroke with three hooks, which was not in the chart.

Rusk looked at it and knew what it was, because he had been an officer for thirty years and the farm had done this before.

"It will ask now," he said.

The book was under his arm. He opened it at the clean page, the one after the line about blood, and stood there with the pen in his hand and did not write.

"Whose name?" Bea said.

Nobody answered her. Meren thought of the column of numbers on the infirmary wall and of nineteen years on this farm and of the one funeral in all of them, and she said what the arithmetic said.

"There is no dead child on Hesper to give it. There has not been one in nine years."

Rusk put his hand flat over the open page, the way a man covers a wound.

"There is one name on this farm," he said. "We said it once. Then we stopped saying it, and we have not said it since, and we never will."

Bea waited for one of them to write something.

Neither of them did.

The Name He Did Not Say

The shape over the flower finished coming up in the night, and by the first shift it stood as clear as anything the plant had ever said: the stem bent twice, and under it a long stroke with three hooks, one after another.

Bea stood below it with the slate against her chest and did not copy it. She had copied it at dusk, when it was only half out, and there is no sense in drawing a thing twice.

"Read it," Meren said. The ring had stopped working for it, the way it stopped when the plant shook.

"Give me a name."

She said it at the roots, in her own voice, because that was the rule. Then she stayed a moment longer with her head back.

"That is all of it. There are three hooks and I do not know what they count."

Nobody spoke for a while. It was the answer the farm had waited for since the flower opened, and the one answer nobody on Hesper had.

"Then the farm answers," Rusk said. He had carried the green journal up from the office before the shift, which meant he had known how the morning would go.

"With what?" Meren said.

"With a name."

"Whose?"

The ring went quiet. Since the morning the officer had written a line with his own name under it and paid for it with a tooth, the farm had agreed, without a vote and without saying it out loud, that the officer wrote what the child read and nothing else.

Meren said the rest anyway, because she was the one who had made a promise in front of witnesses.

"There is no dead child on this farm," she said. "There has not been one since the last flowering. The sign asks for a name, the farm has no name to give it, and I want everybody standing here to hear that before somebody starts offering pieces of himself again."

"There is a request on that page and nothing under it," Rusk said.

"Then there is a request on that page and nothing under it. The farm can live with a page like that. It lived with three days of shaking and a woman holding a bowl under her own hand for all of them."

"I cannot live with it." He said it in the voice he used for the draw in the log, the voice that made people move. "Nine days ago this book learned to hold the plant's questions. Water: the child reads water, and under it the farm writes water. Light: the child reads light, and under it the farm writes light, and I sign the power and the work ring burns dark for a shift. Now the child reads *give me a name*, and the book stops. It has a page for what the plant wants and no page for what the farm will do about it. That is not a book. That is a bucket."

"You want to say it," Bea said.

"I want the farm to answer. Today that is the same sentence."

The woman from the second shift was standing at the edge of the light, the one who had opened her palm on the first morning and held it open for three days. She had not spoken in front of the crew since the bandage came off.

"I will not be in the ring when you say it," she said.

"That is yours to decide."

"He is right," the boy from the water crew said. Fourteen, twice refused, and he said it too loudly, the way he said everything. "Somebody has to answer the plant. That is what an officer is for. If nobody answers, why does anybody work here?"

"Hear the arithmetic first," Meren said, and she put it in the middle of the ring the way she put a number on the infirmary wall. "You wrote one line in that book and the plant got what it wanted inside three days, and it cost you nothing, because the line came true. You wrote a second line and it did not come true, and it cost you a tooth. Write a third that does not come true, and the law goes down the list. Do you know what is under the tooth?"

"A finger."

"Yes."

"Then I will lose a finger," Rusk said, "and the farm will still be standing here under a flower that wants something none of us will say."

"That is not a line about the plant," Meren said. "That is a line about you."

"It is the only line the farm has."

He wrote it at the shelf, slowly, in the square hand he had used for thirty years.

The plant asks for a name. The farm answers with the name it has. I will say it at the roots on the third morning. Rusk.

Bea came and looked at it upside down, the way she looked at all writing, which told her nothing.

"What did you write?"

"That the farm will answer, and that I will say the name on the third morning."

"You have never said it."

"No."

"Then I will be there," she said, "because I am the Reader and I have to hear it," and she went back to her place under the leaves, and nobody told her not to.

* * *

For three days the plant did nothing with the written line, because the plant did nothing with writing.

The leaves stood still. The crown leaned into the two bowl shades and stayed leaning. The gauge over the door held the number it had climbed to the evening the lamps came on, and Meren, who had written a number on the infirmary wall every day for nineteen years, wrote the same number down three times and did not like it. Whatever the officer had put in the book, the plant went on being what it had always been: a thing that wanted clean water when the water was bad and light when the light was low, and had never in thirty years answered anything a man had written about it.

Iven came up from the low ring on the second morning.

He had read the leaves for eleven years, had not read one since the year he lost his tooth, and worked the stores now. He came up the spine with his sleeves down and stood under the shape a long time.

"Did you come to read it?" Rusk said.

"No."

"Then why."

"Because nine years ago I drew a chart on that wall so that nobody would ever have to read a leaf again." Iven kept his eyes on the three hooks. "Signs on one side, words on the other. The farm has been reading out of my chart every morning since, and it has been right about as often as a chart can be right. Now you are going to do the same thing at the shelf. You will write a word, then stand at the roots and do the thing the word says, and you think the plant will notice."

"It will not notice," Rusk said. "I know it will not notice. I am not writing for the plant."

"Then say that part out loud to the crew," Iven said, "because the crew is going to watch you fail and think the plant refused you. It did not refuse you. It does not know you wrote." He turned to go back down the spine, and stopped once. "I lost a tooth for a word I put next to a sign. That is the whole story of my life. Do not lose a finger for the same story."

* * *

That evening Bea asked to hold the book up.

Rusk gave it to her. She carried it to the wall with both hands, open at the page he had written, and held it over her head the way she had held the lamp.

The leaves did nothing. Not the crown, not the low ones by the soil. The plant hung over her with the shape still in it, and the book in her hands was a thing in her hands.

She gave it back, asked the woman from the second shift for the lamp, and held that up instead. Every leaf of the crown turned toward it at once, hundreds of them leaning into the little light like people at a door. They followed it when she moved it along the wall. When she took it away they turned back to the dark.

"Now it can see," Bea said.

Rusk stood with the journal against his chest and looked up at the wall for a while.

"So it has never been listening," he said.

"It is not listening now either," Bea said. "It is looking at the lamp."

Meren went to the gauge and read the number, and wrote nothing, because it had not changed.

"It is not offended," she said. "That is the part I want on the record. The plant is not angry about your line and it is not waiting on it. It is a wall with a flower on it, and the flower is looking at the lamps."

"Then the book was never for it," Rusk said.

"No."

"Then it is for us, and I still wrote it, and I still have to say the name."

* * *

The crew came to the root wall on the third morning without being sent for, the way they came when the plant shook. Bea was under the leaves with the slate. The woman from the second shift stood by the door with her hands behind her, ready to leave, and did not leave.

Rusk opened the journal on the shelf at his line and put his free hand flat on the page.

"*The plant asks for a name*," he said. "The farm answers with the name it has."

He got as far as the first sound of it. The name came up in his mouth and stopped there, and he stood with his mouth open long enough for everyone to see that the officer could not do what he had written.

He closed the book.

"Say it," the boy from the water crew said. "You wrote it."

"I wrote it," Rusk said. "I cannot say it."

"Then the farm pays for a line the officer could not carry out."

"Yes."

"Are you reading?" Bea said, from under the leaves.

"No."

"Then what are you doing?"

"Failing," Rusk said. "In front of everybody, which is the only way it is any use."

Up on the wall the plant did what it had done for two days. The crown leaned into the lamp bowls and stayed leaning, the flower kept its face to the light, and the shape with the three hooks stood over the shelf without changing by a stroke. Nobody in that ring would ever know whether the plant had heard a word of the name: it had not moved for the book, and it did not move for this.

Meren looked at the gauge once more, then at the officer's hand flat on the closed book, and wrote nothing down.

* * *

He woke on the fourth morning and knew before he was properly awake that his left hand was wrong.

The index finger was gone above the middle knuckle. There was no pain and no blood, exactly as the old man had said, and the skin had closed over the joint as if the finger had never been on the hand.

He sat on the edge of his bunk for a while, the way he had sat when it was a tooth. Then he got up and put on his shirt, and found the second button harder than it had ever been, because that was the hand that had always held it.

The crew was at the root wall. Nobody had sent for anybody. Meren had written the morning number on the infirmary wall and come up with the chalk still in her pocket.

Rusk held the hand up where they could see it, because there was no point in making them do the arithmetic out loud.

"Nobody cut anything," the woman from the second shift said.

"Nobody cut anything," Rusk said. "The law does not take it out of the arm that was offered. It takes it out of the man who wrote the line. I have written two lines in this book that did not come true, and I have paid twice, and the plant has not noticed either of them."

"Then stop writing," she said. "Shut the book. Nobody writes, nobody pays."

Meren had thought about that one on the walk up the ring, and she did not like any part of it.

"The law says the requests are written in the green journal," she said. "It is the first thing everybody on this farm knows by heart, before any of the rest. I do not know what happens on a farm where the requests are not written down. Neither do you. Neither does any officer here for nine years. Do you want to find out who the count takes when there is no name at the bottom of the page?"

Nobody answered her.

Rusk turned the book over and looked at the page he had written, at his own name under the line, and then he looked up at the wall, where the flower was still turned to the light and the shape with the three hooks was still standing.

"How long," he said.

"Three days," Meren said. She took the chalk out of her pocket. "The count started again the moment the price was taken. Three days from this morning, and then an eye."

"And after the eye?"

Meren looked at the column of numbers she had kept on the infirmary wall since the year the water went brown, and she said the thing that everybody on the farm had heard since childhood and nobody had ever had to mean.

"There has never been a fourth day."

Above them the crown leaned into the lamplight, and the flower held its face there, and the shape with the three hooks stood over the shelf like a bill the farm had signed and could not pay.

The Shape Without a Word

The ring did what it always did with a price: it went back to work. The second shift had the wall, the gauge had to be read, the stores had to come up from the low ring. Rusk stayed at the shelf, because there was nowhere for an officer to go on the morning his own hand had been paid for.

He had read the page twice already with his right hand. The left lay open on the book with the gap above the middle knuckle, and when he closed it, it was the left that did it, badly.

Meren came up the ring with the chalk in her pocket and stopped where Bea stood under the leaves with the slate against her chest.

"Come down to the stores," she said. "Bring the slate."

"What is in the stores?"

"The old Reader." Meren took the folded chart out of her pocket and put it in the child's hands. It was a quarter of its size and thirty years old. "Three days from this morning there is an eye. We have already spent a tooth and a finger learning that a chart is not a sign. I am not spending an eye on it as well."

* * *

Iven was stacking boxes of gauze against the wall of the low ring, and he did not stop stacking when they came down the spine.

"Teach her," Meren said.

"No."

"She is seven years old and the farm pays for her readings with another man's body."

"I drew the chart so that nobody on this farm would ever have to read a leaf again." He set the box down and looked at her, and then at the child, who was holding his chart the way you hold a thing that has been folded for a long time. "You are asking me to unmake the only useful thing I have done."

"I am asking you to teach her to read the shape and not the word you wrote next to it. There will be another flowering. She has to be ready before it comes."

"Nine years from now," Iven said.

"Two mornings from now," Meren said. "That is when the farm finds out whether it can read."

Iven was quiet for a while. Then he took a crate and pulled it out into the middle of the ring, and put the chart on it, and began to fold the words under.

"One lesson," he said. "And it is not the lesson you came down here for."

* * *

He worked along the chart and turned every word under its own sign, the way a man folds a hem, so that when he was done there was nothing on the paper but shapes.

"You know this one," he said.

Bea looked at the long stroke with the bend at the end. "That is two signs. Blood if the tip turns back toward the stem. Iron in the water if it has the dash across."

He put his thumb over the tip.

"Now."

"I cannot see it."

"Say the word anyway. The farm needs a word. The farm is standing at the shelf right now, waiting for a word."

"I do not know," Bea said.

Iven took his thumb away. He looked at her the way adults on Hesper looked at a gauge that had just been proved right about something they did not want to know.

"That is the first thing I ever learned," he said, "and it cost me a tooth. Now the second thing."

He pushed the crate under the next sign: the dash over the stem, with the end of the stem forked. The chart said *water*.

"That is not water," Bea said.

"The chart says water. I wrote water. Say the word."

"I do not have the right word. But that one is wrong."

"How do you know, if you do not have the right one?"

"Because of the fork." She said it slowly, feeling her way along it out loud.

"Water comes out of the line and it goes one way. This one goes two ways, and nothing in this ring goes two ways except the air."

Iven stood over the crate for a moment and did not correct her.

"Two things, then," he said. "A shape can tell you no. And if you cannot see the end of it, you say so, and you say it in front of adults who want to hear something else. That is everything I know, and it took eleven years and a tooth."

Meren had been standing at the end of the crate with her arms folded, and she had the chalk out of her pocket and did not write anything down, which only happened when a number was already fixed in her.

"Show her the last one," she said.

"No."

"Show her the last one, Iven."

Iven picked the chalk out of her hand, and on the bare wood of the crate he drew the shape that had been standing over the shelf for four days: the stem bent twice, and under it the long stroke, and at the end of the stroke three hooks, one after another.

"How many?" he said.

Bea looked at it a long time. The low ring was quiet, and the vents moved the air the way they always did, and nothing shook.

"It is one line," she said at last, "and the end of it is bent three times."

"How many does it count?"

"I do not think it counts."

"Why not?"

"Nothing up there counts anything." She was still looking at the crate.

"When the plant wanted the water clean it did not ask for three waters. It asked, and then it asked again."

Iven did not answer that. He took the chalk back and did not draw anything else with it, which was an answer of a kind.

"You never drew this one," Meren said.

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because I drew the chart in the year the farm read a sign of mine and paid for it, and I did not draw the ones I was not sure of." He put the chalk in his pocket. "There are four signs on that wall that are not on my chart. That is one of them."

* * *

Meren let him stack two more boxes, and then she asked it.

"Whose name did the farm give it, nine years ago?"

Iven kept his hands on the gauze. "You were the doctor. You were at the funeral."

"I was at the funeral. I was not at the choosing."

"There was no choosing." He said it flatly, in the voice of a man reading a manifest. "There was a sign, and a book, and a Reader who wrote in it."

"The officer writes in it."

"The officer writes in it now." He looked past her, at the chart lying folded open on the crate. "Nine years ago the Reader wrote his own reading, and the book took the price out of the man whose line it was."

"Then it took yours."

"It took my tooth."

Meren stood with that for a moment. It was the first new number she had been given in nine years, and she turned it over the way she turned numbers over.

"And the name?"

"Here is the part that belongs to you," Iven said. "The page is gone out of the register in this ring. Her slate went down the spine with the rest of the stores. Her name is not written on any wall of this farm and it is not said in any ring of it, and I did the taking, one room at a time, because the flower must not hear it. That is what was done."

"That is what was done," Meren said. "I asked how it was chosen."

"I am not answering that."

"Two mornings, Iven. In two mornings the count takes an eye out of the officer because the farm cannot answer a request for a name, and you are standing in your stores folding gauze."

"I am not answering that." Then he said the rest to the child, not to the doctor, and quietly. "I will not put it in your mouth."

Bea had the slate under her arm. "I am the Reader," she said.

"That," Iven said, "is what I am afraid of."

A box moved behind them. The woman from the second shift was standing in the doorway of the stores with her hands behind her back, the way she had stood in the ring on the morning the officer wrote a line about blood. She had opened her palm in front of the crew in the spring and held it open for three days, and no one had ever asked her why she was so quick with a knife.

"He will not answer it because of me," she said. "So I will answer the part that is mine and he can keep the rest."

Meren turned.

"Say it, then," the woman said, "and do not make the child say it back to you. The name the plant carries is my daughter's."

She said the word that was not the name. Nobody in that ring was going to make her do more than that, and Iven, who had taken the name off a page and a slate and a wall, stood with his hands full of gauze and did not look at her at all.

"Nine years," Meren said.

"Nine years," the woman said. "I do not stand under the flower and I do not say it and I do not leave. That is all I have done with it." She looked at the child for a moment. "She was seven," she said, and went back up the spine.

* * *

On the second morning Meren did the other half of the lesson, at the wall, where the farm could hear it.

She stood over the child the way an officer stands over a gauge and made her read the sign four times: the flower sign, the long stroke, the three hooks. The crew stopped working for it, because the crew stopped working for everything that was about the plant.

Bea read it. Then Meren said the thing that was not a reading.

"Now say the part you cannot read."

"The end of it. I do not know what the hooks ask."

"Say it louder."

"I do not know what the hooks ask."

"Again."

"I do not know what the hooks ask."

Afterwards Bea stood with the slate against her chest, and Meren wrote nothing in the air and nothing on paper.

"How does it feel?" Meren said.

"Like he is going to be angry with me."

"He is going to be missing an eye," Meren said. "That is different. Say it once more and then you may go and eat."

Rusk came to the wall while the child was finishing, with the book under his arm and his bad hand held against his chest the way a man holds a hand he does not trust.

"What do we write this morning?" he said.

"Nothing," Meren said.

"Nothing is a word I can write."

"Then write that the farm has not read the sign yet, and write your name under it, if you want the arithmetic to stay honest."

Rusk looked up at the wall. The crown leaned into the two bowl shades, the flower held its face to the light, and the shape with the three hooks stood over the shelf exactly as it had stood on the morning he lost the finger.

"Four days ago I wrote in that book that the farm would answer with the name it has," he said. "I am not taking the line back. It is mine, and it is in the book."

"Nobody is taking it back," Meren said. "You will pay for it in two mornings either way. What we do with the two mornings is read the whole sign in the light and put nothing on that page until the child has read all of it."

"Read it, then," Rusk said, and he stood there with the book under his arm and waited, the way the whole farm had been waiting since the flower opened.

* * *

Bea read it that evening with the hand lamp, and it went the way Iven had taught her, shape first and word after. The flower sign was the flower. The long stroke was the long stroke. The three hooks at the end of it were three hooks at the end of it, and there was nothing anywhere on Hesper that said more than that.

Not one leaf moved. The crown held its face into the lamp and did not care what she said, because it had never cared what anybody said.

She gave the lamp back to the woman from the second shift and went down the spine with the slate, alone, without being sent for, and Iven was still in the stores because the stores never closed.

"Draw it," she said.

"Draw what."

"The one from nine years ago."

He took the chalk back out of his own pocket and knelt down, and drew on the bare wood of the crate: the stem bent twice, the long stroke under it, and then the stroke ended, plain, with nothing at the end of it.

Bea crouched down and looked at the wood for a long time.

"There is nothing at the end," she said.

Iven put the chalk down on the crate beside the drawing.

"There was nothing at the end," he said. Then he wiped his hands on his trousers and stood up. "There are more of those. Come down when you want them drawn, and come without the doctor and without the book."

Above them, up the spine, the crown leaned into the light and the flower stood open over the shelf, and the count on the officer's third line had two mornings left in it.

The Line That Could Not Fail

Rusk was at the shelf before the first shift, with the book open and the pen wet, and the crown burning over his head the way it had burned for four days.

He had done the arithmetic twice on his bunk. Three lines in thirty years; two of them paid for with a front tooth and the first joint of an index finger. In the morning the count came for an eye, and the page would still be holding a request the farm had answered with patience.

Meren came up the ring with the chalk in her pocket and stopped in front of the shelf.

"Put it down."

"Nothing has gone on this page for two days," Rusk said. "The plant asks for a name. The book says the farm has not read the sign. In the morning the count comes, and the page is still clean."

"That is what reading is. You wait for the whole of it."

"We have waited for the whole of it." He turned the book so she could see the last page, and the empty half under it. "The child read the sign end to end in the lamp light and came back with three hooks and no word. She will come back with the same tomorrow, and the same in nine years. I am the officer of this farm. The reading of the leaves is written by the officer; that is what the post is. It was written that way for thirty years before this month."

"Before this month the officer read *blood* off that wall for three days while the water in the trench ran brown."

"And then the child read *iron in the water*, and the line was opened, and the plant stopped shaking." Rusk put the pen down on the page, not beside it. "I wrote a wrong word once. That is not a reason to hand the book to a seven-year-old and stand at the roots with nothing to say."

"You made the rule with me in this ring," Meren said, "in front of the crew, and you are breaking it in front of the child it was made for."

Bea was at the wall with the slate against her chest. She had been standing there long enough to hear all of it, and she did not say again that her reading had been a half reading. She stood where the Reader stood and watched the officer's hand.

"Read me the sign," Rusk said.

"The flower sign. The long stroke. Three hooks at the end of it."

"And the hooks."

"I do not know what the hooks ask."

"Then I will write the part the whole farm agrees on," Rusk said, and wrote.

The plant asks again, as it asked in the spring. The farm knows this asking: blood over the roots, unbandaged, until the plant is still. I give the first. Rusk.

* * *

Meren read the line the way she read a manifest, twice, and then she asked the question that was in it.

"Until the plant is still."

"Yes."

"It has not shaken since the night the lamps came on. Four days."

"I know what I wrote."

"You wrote a line this farm has already kept." Her voice did not rise; she had found the number, and the number was the whole point. "There is nothing in that line for the plant to refuse."

"There is a line in that book," Rusk said. "Four days ago I stood at the roots and could not say the word under the last one. This morning the book has a page under the sign that the farm can pay."

He took the short knife off the hook beside the shelf and walked to the root bed, where the soil lies bare in the trench.

"Do not," Meren said.

"I am not bleeding for a word," Rusk said. "I am bleeding for a page."

He knelt and opened the palm of his left hand over the dirt — the hand with the gap above the middle joint of the index finger — and let the blood run into the soil the way the crew had let it run in the spring, and stayed kneeling with his fingers open.

Nothing happened for as long as it takes to count to ten.

Then the wall turned.

It came down and across in one movement, the way water comes down a sluice: every leaf of the crown swung toward the kneeling man, the low leaves by the soil turned after them, and the open flower, which had held its face into the two bowl shades since the night the lamps came on, tipped over and followed them down, until the whole plant was looking at the wet ground under his hand.

Nobody in the ring made a sound. It was the first time the farm had seen the plant turn for anything a man did with his own body.

"The plant is drinking," the boy from the water crew said. Then he was over the rail with his own knife out, and after him two hands from the first shift, and then a third, and Meren was on the steps with her roll of gauze and no chance of getting there first. Four hands over the soil before the sun came round to the ring.

She bandaged them one after another, standing, without waiting for anything.

"Hold them out," she said. "Under the old rule you would hold them open until it stopped shaking. It stopped shaking four days ago. There is nothing to wait for. You are buying a scar."

"It turned," the boy said. "You all saw it turn."

"I saw it turn," Meren said. "I have seen it turn for a hand lamp."

Bea had come down to the rail and was watching the flower with her head tipped back. "Every time I moved the lamp, the whole crown went with it," she said. "Along the wall. Like that."

"The child is right," Meren said.

"She is right," Rusk said. He was still on his knees while the gauze closed over his palm. "I know she is right. It will not matter."

"Say why it will not matter, because I want that on the record."

"Because the plant does not read," Rusk said. "It never read anything. It turns to what is warm and wet, and it turned to a cut hand for the same reason it turned to a lamp. And the book is the only thing on this farm that has ever told forty-one people what to do. I am not leaving it empty while the count goes for my eye, and I am not the first officer to write down what he believed."

Up on the wall the flower stayed where it had turned, face down toward the soil, and did not come back to the lamps.

* * *

The woman from the second shift came up while they were clearing the trench. She stood at the rail and looked at the four bandaged hands, and then at the stain in the dirt, and she did not take her knife out.

"In the spring I held mine open for three days," she said, "and the water came through the line brown the whole time, and I got nothing for it. This morning the farm pays for a page."

"Go back to your shift," Meren said.

"Nine years ago the book had a line like that one." The woman said it to the shelf, not to either of them. "And the farm paid it with a name. This year it is paying with hands, which is cheaper. I would like to know what any of it is buying."

She went back up the spine. Iven had come up from the stores at the end of the shift, and he stood at the edge of the light with his sleeves down and read the new line twice, and then looked at the child a long while, and went back down without saying anything at all.

* * *

Rusk woke on the third morning and did the counting before he opened his eyes: teeth, one gone; fingers, one joint gone; eyes, both there, and the light over the bunk ordinary.

He sat on the edge of the bunk with his hands on his knees. Then he dressed, which took both hands and three tries at the second button, and went up the ring, where the crew had already gathered at the wall without being sent for.

He held the bandaged hand up where they could see it. Then he turned his face to them and let them see that it was whole.

Meren had the book on the shelf and had read the line again.

"Say the arithmetic," Rusk said.

"There is no unmet request on this page," she said. "The count was running on the name. The book now carries that sign with a line under it, and the farm kept the line the same morning it was written, so the count has nothing to charge. This is the first morning in nine years that a price was due on this farm and was not taken."

"The line could not fail," Rusk said. "Say that part too."

"The line could not fail," Meren said. "You promised blood until the plant is still, and the plant has been still since the lamps came on, so the line was finished the moment the pen left the page. You wrote a page that can always be paid."

"I know."

"Did you know when you wrote it?"

"I knew when I cut." He looked at the bandage. "The cut was not for the plant. It was for the crew, so that the page had a hand behind it and not only a pen."

"And the sign?"

"Unchanged," Meren said. "The plant is not reading the book. Whatever the three hooks ask, it asked it before this morning and it is asking it now."

She took the chalk out of her pocket and went to the infirmary wall, and wrote the morning's number at the bottom of the column. It was the same number as the day before, and the day before that.

"Then here is what I will put on my wall instead of a line in yours," she said. "When the gauge moves, we find out what the farm answered. Not before."

* * *

The crown lamps burned all that day while the work ring stayed dark, because the margin had gone four days ago to a light the plant had wanted. The sign stood over the shelf without changing by a stroke: the flower sign, the long stroke, three hooks one after another.

But the open flower did not turn back to the shades. It held its face down toward the trench where the blood had gone into the soil, and it stayed like that through the shift, and through the night, and into the next morning.

The One Who Remembers

Rusk called the farm to the root wall before the first shift, and the farm came, because in thirty years no officer had called it to anything but a reading.

The book lay open on the shelf with yesterday's line and his name under it, and nothing standing against it in the count. The crown lamps burned over the leaves. The flower stood open above the shelf with its face down at the trench, and the sign with the three hooks had not changed by a stroke in eight days.

"The law says the flowering is given a name," Rusk said. "The book has four lines in it and not one of them says what a choosing is. I have read that book for thirty years and there is no such line in it, and no such line in me."

The ring waited.

"So the farm will make one. Here, under the sign, this morning, in front of everybody."

"Say the rest," Meren said.

"There is no dead child on Hesper." He said that to the ring and not to her. "Nine years since the last funeral, and that child carries the plant's name already. The law says a dead child. The farm has none."

"The low ring has a few hundred of them," the woman from the second shift said. She stood at the rail with her hands behind her back. "The register keeps every birth and every death on the page of its year. There are children on those pages. They are only not ours any more."

"Then the farm takes one of them," the boy from the water crew said. He held his bandaged hand up while he said it. "The oldest one. The one no hand in this ring remembers. The plant does not hear names — the doctor said so in this ring four days ago. So let it have a word out of a book and let the ring go back to work."

"Before this farm spends anything else," Meren said, "the child reads the whole sign in front of it. That has been the rule of this ring since the first morning, and the officer wrote it into the book himself."

"I wrote it," Rusk said.

"Then nothing goes on that page this morning until she has read it." Meren put the chalk back in her pocket. "Bea. Go down to the stores. No book, and I am not coming."

* * *

Iven had the crate out in the middle of the low ring before she was down the last of the steps.

"I heard it from here," he said. "Sit, and put the slate where I can see it."

He drew with the chalk on the bare wood. The flower sign; the long stroke under it; and at the end of the stroke, nothing.

"That is the one from nine years ago," Bea said.

"That is the one from nine years ago." He drew beside it: the same flower, the same stroke, and at the end of the stroke a single hook. "And that is the one before it. I read that one too. Eighteen years ago the farm read it and gave its name the same day. Nine years ago it read this one and gave its name the same day. This morning it is standing at the wall with a shape it has had for eight days and no name in it."

Bea looked at the two drawings and then up the spine.

Three hooks. One hook. None.

"Say what changes," Iven said.

"It is the same shape until the end."

"And the end."

She put her finger near the third drawing without touching the wood, the way she read a leaf. "That is the tip of the blood sign. The blood sign is the long stroke with its tip turned back toward the stem. This is that same turn, three times, one after the other."

"What does the turn say?"

"Blood comes back out of the stem," Bea said. "The tip turns back, so the thing goes back where it came from." She stopped there, and then went on slowly, feeling for the edge of it. "Three turns is not three of anything. Nothing on that wall counts. The sign does not ask for a number. The farm counts. The three days are ours."

Iven sat back against the wall of gauze.

"That is everything I know," he said, "and it took me eleven years and a tooth. Now say why you came down here without the doctor."

"To hear what you wrote."

"I thought so." He put the chalk down. "Nine years ago I read the sign I have just drawn for you, and I read it the way the farm reads: the plant wants a name. So I wrote my reading in the book, and under my reading I wrote the other thing."

"What other thing?"

"That she would be kept." He said it flatly, at the crate. "The farm will keep her among its own: in its register, in its speech, in the mouths of the people who knew her. That was my line. That is the line the book took the tooth for."

"The farm gave her to the flower, and then it took her off the page and off the slate and off the walls, room by room, and the men who did that were me and two hands who are dead now. That is the opposite of keeping. So my line did not come true, and on the third morning the tooth was out of my head while I slept."

"But the farm did everything the sign asked. The name was given."

"The name was given." Iven picked the chalk up and did not draw with it.

"The book does not care whether a line is a request or a promise. A line is a debt of the hand that wrote it. Mine said the farm would keep her and the farm did not keep her, and I have not written a line since."

"And who chose her?"

"The year she died there was one name on that page." He looked at the drawing of the nine-year sign. "There was no choosing. There was a hand on a page. That is what the farm calls a choosing, and that is what I am coming up the spine to say to it."

* * *

They carried the crate up between them, and Iven came with it without being asked, which the ring noticed.

Bea read the three drawings at the wall, standing on the crate, with the crew in front of her and the flower overhead. She said the shape first and the words after, the way she had been taught: the flower sign, the long stroke under it, the end of that stroke turned back three times toward its own stem. Then she said the part the farm had not heard before.

"The hooks do not count. The shape does not ask for three of anything. An end turned back three times is a thing that comes back, and the three is the farm's own law, the three days we keep in the book."

"Then the sign is not counting us down," Meren said.

"The sign has never counted anything," Bea said. "We count. And the count is on the writer, not on the plant."

Rusk stood at the shelf with his hand flat on the book and said nothing.

"Then here is what I have," the woman from the second shift said. "You want the oldest name in that register. The one no hand up here remembers, so that the flower gets a word and nobody gets a wound. I have watched this farm buy a page with hands. Do it this morning and the ring learns that lesson a second time: that a name is paper. And the next time somebody wants a page written, he will open a palm over the soil again, and the child will be standing there to watch it."

"Then what," the boy from the water crew said.

"A name is a name while somebody is holding it." She looked at the shelf, not at him. "Spend one that is being held."

Meren turned the chalk over once in her hand.

"Then here is the rule this farm makes this morning," she said. "The flowering is given the name of a dead child of Hesper, and the only hand that may give it is a hand that remembers the child. Said out loud at the roots, once, by that hand. Not by the officer. Not by the child. Not by the book."

"I wrote in the spring that my own voice would answer at the roots," Rusk said. "That line is in the book."

"That line is in the book, and it was paid for with a finger," Meren said, "and on the morning it came due you could not say one word of it in front of this ring. The law let that line go. The farm has not. That is why the voice is not yours."

Rusk looked at the ring, and the ring looked back at him.

"Take the voice," he said at last. "I will write it."

* * *

They brought the register up the spine between the boy and two hands of the first shift, and set it on the crate, and the ring read it the way the ring read the gauge.

Its first page was older than anyone aboard. Every year had a page, and in six of those years a page was missing: cut out at the binding, with the stub left in the book, a finger wide.

"Six," Meren said, and counted the stubs with her finger, "in six years."

"Six flowerings," Iven said from the edge of the crate. "And each of those holes is a whole year, not a name: the births with it, the deaths with it. That is what this plant has cost this farm, and there is nothing on any wall that says so."

Then the ring read the names the surviving pages carried, the children who had died in years when the flower was not open. The boy read two out; a hand from the second shift stopped in the middle of another, because reading a dead child's name in a ring is not the same as reading it alone.

Nobody in the ring could put a face to any of them.

"Put your finger on it," Verrin said.

She was the oldest hand on Hesper; she worked the trench and had stood at the rail all morning without a word. She came down to the crate and put her hand flat on the open page. "The year a crate came off the rack in the spine and killed the girl who had the bunk above mine. I was seven. Her mother went down on the next manifest and stayed down, and there has been nobody else to hold her since. She is the one on these pages that is still being carried."

The ring was quiet.

"Then the rule can be kept," Meren said.

"With three things." Verrin kept her hand on the page. "The holes stay open, and the number stands in the green journal with the line, so the farm's count of what it spent stands next to the count of its days. When the Reader is old enough to hold it, she is told that a name was spent here and will never be given to her, so that the silence is a thing the farm knows and not a hole in it. And I say it in the trench, over the soil where the hands went in, because that ground is the only thing on this farm that has ever been given anything."

"Write it," Meren said to Rusk. "And write it so that it asks for nothing."

Rusk wrote, standing at the shelf with the book on his forearm, and the ring watched the pen.

The flowering has been given a name. The name is a child of Hesper who died in a year when this plant was not flowering. It was said once at the roots by the only hand that remembers her. It is not written here and it will not be said again. The farm has spent seven names on this plant, and the register keeps the holes. This line asks for nothing. Rusk.

* * *

The ring went down into the trench the way it went to a reading. The crew stood on the steps; Bea sat on the rail with the slate against her chest; Rusk stood at the bottom with the book open on his arm.

Verrin stepped down onto the bare soil where the four hands had gone in. She did not stand on the dark patch; she stood beside it.

She said the name once. It was a word of two sounds, said at the ground, loud enough for the ring.

Nothing in the wall moved. Not a leaf of the crown, not the low leaves, not the flower that had been looking at the trench for five days. The ring stood in the trench and waited past the point where anything could still arrive.

The woman from the second shift stood at the rail through the whole of it. Nine years ago she had not been in the ring.

Rusk signed the line. Meren wrote the morning's number at the foot of her column on the infirmary wall, and it was the same number as the day before.

Iven carried the register back down the spine under his arm, to cut the year's page out of it with the others, and nobody went with him.

Bea stayed on the rail with her head tipped back, looking up the wall where everyone else had stopped looking.

The flower was still open, and its face was not on the dark patch where the four hands had bled. It was a hand's width past it, at the seat where the root line comes up out of the manifold into the soil.

For five days the farm had stood under that flower and said the plant was looking at the blood, and nobody had looked where the flower was looking.

What the Page Cost

Rusk was at the shelf before the first shift with the book open, and the ring came up without being called, the way it had come every morning since the sign with the three hooks stood over the leaves.

Nothing had moved. The crown lamps burned above the wall; the plant stood under them with its body turned down at the trench, and the open flower was still aimed a hand's width past the patch of soil where the four hands had gone in, at the seat where the root line comes up out of the manifold. The sign over the shelf had not changed by a stroke in nine days: the flower, the long stroke, three hooks at the end of it.

Meren wrote the morning's number at the foot of her column on the infirmary wall. It was the same number as the day before, and the six days before that.

"The farm did what the sign asked," Rusk said. He said it to the ring, with his hand flat on the open page. "A name was given at the roots, once, by a hand that remembers. The register has a hole in it for the year. The book has a line under the sign that asks for nothing. That is everything Hesper has done for nine days, and the wall has not moved a leaf for any of it."

"Write down what you want," Meren said, "and stop making it into a speech."

"Then here is what I want." He turned the book so that the last page lay open towards the crew. "Yesterday this ring made a rule at this wall. A name may be given to the flowering only by a hand that remembers the child, said out loud at the roots, once, and never written. It is a good rule. It cost the farm a year of its register and it will hold you all for the rest of your lives. But the book cannot carry it. There is no line under that sign that says a choosing happened here, what was chosen, or when. The seventh name this farm has spent on this plant stands in one head, and this morning that head is seventy-one years old."

"The rule was made in front of the crew," Meren said. "It does not need your pen to stand."

"Everything else this farm knows stands in that pen." He tapped the page. "Every reading, every request, every price. When the trench hands want to know what the plant asked in the spring, they read the book. When Verrin is dead, what does the farm read?"

"The hole in the register," Meren said. "The way it reads the other six."

Verrin was at the rail with the trench crew, and she did not answer him, and Bea sat above them on the rail with the slate against her chest and watched the officer's hand the way she always watched it.

* * *

He wrote standing, with the book on his forearm, and the ring watched the pen.

The name said at the roots on the fifteenth day is entered under this sign by the officer of Hesper, with the other lines of this plant, so that the farm's choosing stands in the book and not in one memory. I will enter it before the count. Rusk.

Meren read it twice, the way she read a manifest. "You cannot keep that."

"No," Rusk said. "Not without a hand that will say the name to me."

He put the pen down and went along the ring to the trench, and the crew made way for him, and Verrin came up out of the root bed with soil on her forearms and stood on the steps below the shelf.

"I need the name," Rusk said.

"You heard it on the fifteenth day with everyone else." Verrin looked up at him without moving her feet. "It was said once, at the roots, loud enough for the ring. That was the giving."

"I need it written."

"Then you need a different thing than the one this farm voted for." She wiped her hands on her thighs. "I gave you three terms and the ring took them. The holes stay open and the count stands in the book. The child is told, when she is old enough to hold it, that a name was spent here and will never be given to her. And the name is said at the roots, not written down. You were standing right there when I said the third one."

"I wrote the third one."

"You signed it, and now you are asking me to unwrite it."

"I am asking you to say it once more, to me, so that the farm's own record has it." He held the book up. "If you die tonight, the farm has spent a name it cannot say, cannot write, and cannot read. Six holes in a register and a seventh that nobody can open. What has this farm bought for a whole year of its dead?"

"It bought a name," Verrin said. "You want paper. Paper is what this farm has been buying with hands, and you know it better than I do, because it is your hand on the pen."

"Verrin—"

"I will not say it twice." She said it the way she said things in the trench, flat and final. "Not for a page, not for the record, not for your eye. And you may want to hear this part too, officer. That line is not mine, and no hand of mine is under it. The book charges the name at the bottom. You wrote yours."

* * *

Two days went by.

On the morning of the seventeenth the boy from the water crew took the green journal off the shelf without being asked and held it up at the wall where the child had held it in the spring, open at the last page, both covers flat, so that every leaf in the crown had the officer's line facing it.

The wall did not move. Not the crown, not the low leaves, not the flower that had been looking at the trench for a week.

"Say it," he said.

"It does not read," Meren said. "The gauge in my ring has not moved for eight days. The book has been open on that shelf the whole time, and the plant has not turned one leaf towards it."

"Then the plant took the officer's tooth without reading a word of what he wrote."

"The plant took nothing. A page was not kept and a price was owed, and the price is not the plant's business." She took the book out of his hands and set it back on the shelf, closed. "The count is the farm's law. That is what the child told this ring a week ago and none of you listened to her then either."

Meren went to Rusk at the end of the shift, where he sat on the steps with his hands on his knees.

"Close it," she said. "Write a line over this one. The count is charged against the request that stands under a line, and a new line over the same sign closes the old count — you did it in the spring with the blood, and the ring watched you do it. One sentence, and the count is gone."

"And the sign has no line under it that says any choosing happened."

"The sign never had one. The sign stood over this shelf for nine years with nothing under it at all."

"Nine years ago there was nobody who could write one." Rusk looked at the shelf. "I can. And if I write over it, then in twenty years there is a book here with six holes in the register downstairs, seven names paid out of the farm's dead, and one line in the book saying a choice was made. I would rather wear the price of the page than strike the page out."

"That is a very fine sentence," Meren said. "I will put it in my column next to the numbers, where it belongs."

* * *

He woke in the dark of the third morning and did the arithmetic before he opened his eyes: teeth, one gone, from the spring; fingers, one joint gone, from the choosing; and then he lay still and passed his hand over his face and found the third thing.

There was no pain. There was no blood on the pillow. The lid lay down over a smooth place, closed the way a gum closes, and the light of the ring, when he stood at the rail, came into his right eye alone, while the left side of the world was simply not there and not dark either — a closed door in a familiar house.

The ring was already at the wall when he came up, because the news had gone up the spine ahead of him.

"Say the arithmetic," Rusk said.

Meren made him sit on the crate and looked at the lid and the socket under it, and there was nothing on the farm to dress.

"The price is taken in the night, and it costs no blood and no pain, and the farm has known that since your tooth," she said. "You are the first officer of Hesper to pay the third one. There is no fourth one written anywhere. Nine years ago the Reader stopped at a tooth and left the post. You have paid the ladder to its top in seven days and the line is still standing."

"Then the count restarts on the same line," Rusk said. "Three days."

"Three days." She stood back and looked at him and did not soften it. "And nobody in this ring, including the child, can tell you what the law takes when the ladder is finished and the count runs again."

The woman from the second shift came up to the crate and stood in front of him the way she had stood in front of the shelf for nine years.

"Yesterday you would not let the ring strike the page out," she said. "Now the seventh name of this farm has cost an eye, and it is still not written anywhere. Tell me what you bought."

"Time," Rusk said. "The ring's rule stands, the name is where it was, and the farm has three more days to find a way to keep a line that says what it chose."

"Three days is what everybody on this farm always has," she said, and went back to her shift.

* * *

At the end of the day Rusk took the book down into the trench, opened it at the last page, and held it up where the flower was aimed — at the seat where the root line comes up out of the manifold and into the soil.

He held it there for as long as it takes to count to twenty.

The wall did not move. Not one leaf of the crown, not one leaf at the soil.

"It is looking under my hands," he said at last. "It is not looking at the page."

Bea was on the rail above him with her slate, and she said, out loud, in the voice the farm had made a rule about: "It never looked at the page. It has been looking at the seat."

The boy from the water crew came down the steps and stood beside the seat with his hand on the wheel of the bypass that Meren had opened in the spring. He looked at Rusk, and Rusk nodded, and the boy turned the wheel a quarter turn.

The low leaves by the soil turned towards the seat first, all of them together, the way a hand turns. Then the open flower came up off the trench for the first time in six days, a hand's width, and stood with its face on the line where the water comes in. The crown followed it, in one movement, off the lamps it had held all week.

Nobody said anything for a while.

Then Meren went up the steps and stood in front of her column on the infirmary wall with the chalk in her hand. The morning's number was at the foot of it, the same as the day before. She looked at the gauge, and at the man with one eye at the bottom of the steps, and at the page held open in his hand.

She wrote the new number under the old one, and it was a tenth higher.

"Eight days of writing," she said, "and one wheel."

Rusk closed the book and put his hand on the cover and stayed where he was, in the trench, with the flower off the soil and turned at the line, and the sixth line standing open on the page above the name sign of a plant that had never read anything in its life.

What the Wall Stopped Asking

The count restarted on the eighteenth day, so the nineteenth was its first morning, and Rusk had the book open on the shelf before the shift bell.

Meren came up the steps with her chalk still in her hand and read the arithmetic off his face.

"Nineteen, twenty, twenty-one," she said. "The night before the twenty-first. Nothing on the ladder above an eye, and nobody on this farm who can tell you what the law takes when the ladder is finished."

"I am not going to spend two mornings finding out," Rusk said.

The ring came up behind her the way it had come up every morning since the flowering began, and stood along the rail with the shift not started. The crown lamps burned over the wall. The sign with the three hooks stood under them unchanged, and the flower was open above the shelf with its face turned down at the trench.

He turned the book so that the last page lay open towards the crew.

"On the seventeenth day the doctor told me the thing I already knew and would not use. The count is charged against the request that stands under a line, and a new line written over the same sign takes the charge off the old one." He put his hand flat on the page. "I told her then that I would rather wear the price than strike the choosing out of this book. I was wrong about the page. A new line strikes nothing out. Both lines stay, one above the other, and what goes is the count."

"Then what does the new line say," Meren said.

"It says the name."

The ring did not move. Then the woman from the second shift spoke from the back of it, without stepping forward.

"Not by the officer," she said. "That was the rule this ring made on the fifteenth day, with the register open in front of it. Not by the officer, not by the child, not by the book."

"There was a reason for it." Rusk said that to her and not to Meren. "The reason was that a name is a name only while a hand is holding it, and Verrin is holding this one. Verrin is the oldest hand on this farm, and yesterday, in the trench, in front of the ring, she told me she will not say it twice. So this morning the farm has a name in one head, and that head is seventy-one, and two mornings are left before the law takes something out of me that nobody here can name."

The boy from the water crew came down to the first step with his bandaged hand held up, which was his way of asking to be listened to.

"You are going to write a word and call it an answer," he said. "A fortnight of writing in that book. I turned the wheel at the seat and the flower came up off the soil in front of the whole ring, and the doctor's column moved a tenth for the first time since the lamps came on. That is the only thing on this farm that has ever answered anything, and it did not come out of a pen."

"No," Rusk said. "It did not. And I am not writing over your wheel."

"You are writing over the rule," the woman from the second shift said.

"I am writing past a memory." He said it to the rail. "When Verrin is gone there is nothing under that sign that says this farm ever chose anything. The next officer opens the register the way this ring wanted to on the fifteenth day, takes the oldest word on a surviving page, because a word nobody is holding is cheap, and the farm spends another year of its dead on it. You stopped that once. From a grave you cannot stop it again."

"It is not yours to write," she said.

"No," Rusk said. "It is hers. I heard it once, at the ground, and I am going to put it down."

* * *

Meren took the book off the shelf and read the last page with her finger under the words, the way she read a manifest.

"You heard it once," she said. "Under an open flower, at the roots, in front of the whole ring."

"Once."

"Then write it. And then hand me the book, and I will read the name out loud to these people, so that what goes on the page is heard by everybody it belongs to."

"No."

The ring heard how flat he said it. Meren looked up.

"When this farm spent the last name it spent it out loud," Rusk said, "and then it took the child off the register page, off her slate and off the walls, room by room, until that name stood nowhere at all. This one goes into the book and stays in it. A written name is a name nobody has to say. Your mouth, doctor, is where this farm has always lost them."

Verrin was at the rail with the trench crew and had not looked at the shelf once.

"Paper is quieter than a mouth," she said. "I will give you that. And paper is what this farm reads on the mornings when it wants to know what to do to itself. You are putting her where the orders live."

Rusk opened the book. He wrote standing, with the page on his forearm, and the ring watched the pen.

The name said at the roots on the fifteenth day is entered under this sign by the officer of Hesper, from his own hearing, so that the farm's choosing does not stand in one head and nowhere else. This line takes the charge off the sixth line above it and asks for nothing else. Rusk.

Between the second line and the third he put down the two sounds of the name, the way a name goes into a register, and the ring watched the pen make them, and nobody said them.

He signed it, and closed the book.

"The count is off my sixth line," he said.

"So it is," said Meren.

* * *

He carried the book along the rail to where Verrin stood.

"Read the entry," he said. "Tell the ring whether I heard it."

"No."

"Verrin. If I heard it wrong, it stands in that book as long as this farm stands."

"Then you had better have heard it right." She wiped her hands on her thighs and looked at the closed book, not at him. "I said it once at the roots, the way this ring told me to say it. I will not say it a second time to check a man's ear, and I will not read a page to find out what I said. What is in there is what this farm will have in nine years, when the hand that reads it never heard her at all."

The woman from the second shift had come the length of the rail and stood looking at the cover.

"Nine years ago this farm took a name off a page," she said. "This morning it has put one on. There is a hand in this ring that can tell you whether you heard it right, officer, and she has just told you no."

* * *

Nothing happened on the twentieth day.

The book lay open on the shelf at the new line, and the wall stood exactly as it had stood: crown, low leaves, and the sign with the three hooks not changed by a stroke. Meren wrote the morning's number at the foot of her column and it was the same as the day before.

"The book has never moved anything," she said, "and I am not going to stand here and watch it. The plant is drinking or it is not, and that is a thing I can measure."

She sent the boy down to the seat with her orders. He opened the bypass wheel another quarter turn, and the number moved again: a second tenth, the second movement since the flowering began.

"Two movements in my column," Meren said, "and both of them came off that wheel. I have no story to go with them. Put it in your book if you like; I have put it on my wall."

* * *

The farm came up in the dark on the twenty-first to watch the law take whatever it takes above an eye.

Nothing was taken.

Meren made Rusk sit on the crate and looked at the lid that was already closed and at the hand with the missing joint, and there was nothing on him that was new.

The ring waited past the point where anything could still arrive. The boy from the water crew said out loud what the ring was thinking: the count was off his line, the officer kept his face, and the book had done it — a fortnight of a plant that had never once turned a leaf for a page, and now the law had nothing left to charge.

Then, in the middle of that morning, the flower closed.

Bea saw it first, because she was sitting on the rail with her head back, the way she always sat. The petals that had stood open above the shelf through the whole flowering turned down and came together, and the flower bowed on its stem and lay with its face on the seat where the root line comes up out of the manifold into the soil.

Then the wall let go. The long stroke under the crown untied itself leaf by leaf, and the three hooks came apart last, the way a knot comes apart when the hand holding it opens.

Where the sign had been there were leaves, flat and still, not one of them turned.

"It stopped," Bea said.

"It read it," said the boy from the water crew. "The morning after the officer writes the name, it puts the whole sign away and closes."

"The plant has never read anything." Meren said that to the ring and not to him. "It stood in front of an open book in the spring and did not move, and it stood in front of the same book over that seat a week ago and did not move."

"Then why did it stop this morning," the boy said.

"I do not know," Meren said. "I have a column with two numbers in it, and both of them moved for a wheel."

Bea slid down off the rail and stood under the empty wall with the slate against her chest, and the ring asked her what the sign said now.

"There is no sign," Bea said. "It is not asking any more. It did not answer. It stopped asking."

The ring did not take that up, because it had a quiet wall on its hands for the first time in the book, and every hand on the farm could see that the plant was done, and only the child had said the word *stopped*.

Rusk stood at the shelf with the book closed under his arm and did not say which of them he believed. On the page, under the sign that was no longer on the wall, both lines stood: the sixth, which he had not kept, and the seventh, which had cost him nothing.

The woman from the second shift went along the rail to the steps.

"Nine years of quiet, then," she said. "And then it flowers again and asks again, and the name comes off that page, officer, in your writing, and there will be nobody left in this ring who ever heard her. You have bought this farm nine years of not having to remember."

* * *

The shift started late, and the crew went about the farm.

Rusk went down into the trench slowly, because with one eye the steps have no depth and he had learned to feel for them. At the bottom he stood at the seat where the wheel is, where the root line comes up into the soil, and looked at the line he had written and at the flower lying over it with its face on the water.

Bea came down after him. She stood at the edge of the soil and looked at the leaves along the root line for a while without saying anything.

"Officer," she said at last. "That one is new."

In the leaves that lie along the pipe, where the root line comes out of the manifold, a shape had come up while nobody was watching: low, small, no bigger than a thumbprint, and turned at the water.

"I do not know that one," Bea said.

The Hand That Has to Say It

The twenty-second morning came up with nothing standing over the shelf.

The crown lamps burned above the root wall and the leaves lay flat under them, the way they had lain since the sign came apart. The flower lay closed on the seat where the root line comes up out of the manifold, its face down on the water. There was no shape to read and no count running in the book, and the ring came up to the wall anyway, as it had every morning for three weeks.

Meren was at the gauge before anyone else.

"The plant is drinking," she said. "That is the whole of what it ever asked us for. The boy goes down to the seat before the first shift and reads the wheel, and I write what the line takes. Any hand that wants to know what this farm owes that thing can read my wall."

"One quarter turn," the boy from the water crew said from the steps, holding his bandaged hand up. "It came off the trench in front of the whole ring."

"Two," Meren said. "And two tenths. Neither of them came out of that book."

Rusk stood at the shelf with the green journal open at the last page. He had nothing to write under it and he had come up anyway.

Bea was on the rail with her head tipped back, looking at the empty wall. She had looked at it every morning since the flower closed, and the ring had stopped asking her what she saw, because there was nothing to see.

"Reader," he said. "The small one. In the leaves along the pipe at the foot of the trench."

"It is still there." Bea did not take her head back. "It has not grown."

"What does it ask."

She was quiet long enough that the crew began to shift. Then she slid down off the rail and stood under the wall and said it the way she said a reading, in her own voice, with the words after the shape.

"It is not turned at me. It is not turned at the shelf and it is not turned at the ring. Every morning it is turned at the water, the way the flower was turned at the seat." She put her hand flat on the rail. "It is not asking us for anything. It is looking at the line."

Meren nodded once, at the gauge.

"Then the farm's answer is the wheel and the number," she said. "Two hands on the line every shift. Water that has not been through a hole in a valve seat. That is the whole of our religion."

* * *

"The sign will come back in nine years," Rusk said, "and when it does it will ask for a name, and this morning I want the farm to do the thing it has never done."

He turned the book so that both lines stood open towards the rail.

"Nine years ago there was one name on the year's page and a hand wrote it. This year there was one hand in the ring that could give one, and it gave it, and there was no choosing in that either. So I ask the ring: in nine years, from where does the name come, and who says it out loud."

"From whoever died," the boy said.

"Say the rest of that," Meren said.

"From whoever died in the nine years. There will be somebody. There always is."

"Then we are choosing a child who is not dead yet," the woman from the second shift said from the rail. "This ring is going to stand here and decide whose funeral it needs."

"I did not say it well," the boy said.

"You said it exactly," said Verrin.

She came up the steps from the trench with soil to her elbows, and the ring made room for her the way it always did.

* * *

They brought the register up the spine, because the ring asked for it, and Iven came with it under his arm, which meant he had been waiting with it since before the shift bell.

He set it on the crate and opened it where the stubs are.

"Seven," Meren said, and counted them with her finger, the way she had counted them on the fifteenth day.

"Seven names and seven whole years," Iven said. "Read them out and you will see why the officer is standing there with a pen in his hand."

So the ring read the pages the register still had. The boy read two names out and stopped, because they were children from a year nobody at the wall had been born in; a hand of the second shift read three more and stopped in the middle of the fourth, because a name read aloud in a ring is not a name read alone.

Not one hand at the wall could put a face to any of them.

"That is the pool," Verrin said, when the reading stopped. "Hundreds of names on those pages, and not one face behind them. Now ask your question again, officer. Who is going to say it out loud?"

"I can teach the reading," Iven said. "I have taught it once. A mouth can be trained onto a page."

"That is not reading," Bea said it from the rail without turning round.
"That is saying."

The ring went quiet, and the woman from the second shift took one step forward, which on that farm was a speech.

"There are two children in this ring that anybody could still see if they closed their eyes," she said. "The girl who had the bunk above Verrin's, and mine. Both of them are spent. Mine carries nothing now and may still not be said on this farm, and the other one the plant keeps. So when the next sign comes up and asks, every mouth here will be holding a name it is forbidden to say, and the register will be holding a few hundred names with no face on them at all." She looked at the shelf and not at Rusk. "That is the choosing you want written down. The farm has to choose between a page and a mouth, and this morning it has neither."

* * *

Two answers stood up in the ring and neither of them fell down.

"A page is a page," the boy from the water crew said, standing on the first step with his hand up. "The plant does not hear a word, the doctor has said so twice, and the man with the pen showed us what a line costs when it asks for nothing: the count came off his head and nothing was taken. So let him write the choosing. The farm gives the next flowering the oldest name in the register, and no child on this farm is ever picked for a funeral again."

"That is the cheapest thing this ring has ever been offered," Verrin said. "It was offered once before. I was standing where you are standing when the farm took a page, and the price of that page walked around this ring for a tooth and a finger and an eye, and it was not the plant that did the taking."

"What did the page cost us, then," the boy said. "Say it in numbers."

"The officer's face," Meren said, with the chalk still in her hand. "And a name in that book that no living hand can check, and a child on the rail who walks past that line every morning of her life. You want the next choosing written the same way."

"I want nobody to die for it."

"So do we," said Verrin. "That is not the choice."

The second answer was Meren's, and the ring knew which way it would go.

"A name is a name while a hand is holding it," Meren said. "The woman from the second shift said it on the fifteenth day, the ring took it, and the officer's pen then did what it liked with it, so I will say the rest of it now. If this farm wants to have a name when the sign comes back, it has to have hands that hold one — hands that knew the child alive, and not hands that read a page and say the sounds. That is all a keeping is. The farm's whole problem is that it has spent both of the children it was still holding, and it has no third."

* * *

Rusk put the book down on the shelf and left it there, closed, and did not touch the pen again that morning.

"Then say the rule," he said. "I will write nothing. What the ring makes this morning stands in no line of that book, if that is what the ring wants."

"It is what the ring wants," Meren said. "A rule with no line has no count on it, and that cuts both ways, officer, and we have all seen that too."

"Then here is what the ring made on the twenty-second day," Verrin said, and she said it slowly, with the register open beside her. "The flowering is given the name of a dead child of Hesper. The choosing is done here, at this wall, in front of the ring, and never in a room. A hand may offer a child it knew alive. No hand is ever asked for one, because a name said to order is paper. Any hand in the ring may refuse an offering, and the hand that offers it is the hand that says the name at the roots, once, out loud, the way I said mine."

"And the day the name is given," the woman from the second shift said. "What does the farm keep of the child afterwards? Nine years of quiet, in my case, and a hole in a register."

"That is the second thing," Meren said, "and it is the doctor's business. The farm will say its dead out loud. One day a year, at this wall, at the shift bell, the ring says the names of the children this farm has lost — said, not read, from mouths and not off a page. The day the flowering began is the day for it. Whoever holds a name says it, and the child who reads the leaves is to know the farm's dead the way she knows the wall."

Nobody spoke for a moment. Then the boy from the water crew said: "Say the first one."

Meren looked at the register on the crate, and at the seven stubs, and at the woman from the second shift, and at Verrin.

"The first one is this morning," she said. "There is nothing to say. Every child this farm could still name is already the plant's, and the names on those pages belong to nobody here. The keeping stands empty this year, and that is what nine years without a funeral bought us."

Meren wrote the morning's number at the foot of her column, the same as the day before, and the shift started.

* * *

Verrin took Bea down into the trench at the end of it, under the closed flower, and stood her on the steps where the soil is bare.

"You have been told what the ring voted on the fifteenth day," she said. "I am doing my part of it now, and then it is done. A name was spent here. It was said once, over this ground, by me. It is in no page of that register and no page of that book in any words you can read, and it will never be given to you, and that is not a thing the ring does to you. It is a thing the ring is keeping you out of."

"Will you still have her in nine years," Bea said.

"No."

"Then the farm has to put her somewhere that lasts longer than a mouth."

Bea was quiet, and then she said it in the flat way she read a sign, with the words after the shape.

"Then say them to me. All of the ones you have got. I will hold what you give me, and I will not ask for the one the flower is holding." She looked up. "The keeping is mine. I read the leaves. Nobody else in this ring is still going to be here when the sign comes back."

Verrin stood with soil on her forearms and did not answer her for a while.

"You are seven," she said at last.

"The other Reader was eleven years in the post," Bea said. "And he is the one who told me that the farm writes down what it wants to keep."

* * *

The woman from the second shift was at the rail when the ring came up for the second shift, and she had waited for the shelf to be empty.

"Officer," she said. "The day the ring made this morning. The keeping."

"It stands," Rusk said. "It is in no line, but it stands."

"Put my daughter in it."

He looked at her with the one eye he had left.

"You know what the law says."

"I have kept it nine years without being asked." She said it evenly, with her hands behind her back. "The farm may not mention her again, because the flower would be offended. Nobody here has ever tested whether that flower hears a mouth at all — you wrote a name into a book in front of me and it read nothing, and my daughter's name has been off every wall for nine years while the plant carried it." She nodded at the flat wall. "So there is my request. It is a request, not a line, and nothing is charged to anybody for it. Say her name at the wall once a year, with the others, and let the ring hear it."

Rusk stood at the shelf with the closed book under his arm and did not answer her, because the ring was coming up behind her and it was her shift, and above the shelf the wall lay flat and unturned over a book that had never moved one leaf of it.

Afterword

Hesper keeps two records of the same thing. One is the green journal, where a request becomes a line, and the line, once written, becomes the debt of the hand that wrote it. The other is a column of numbers on the infirmary wall, where a doctor writes down what the air actually did. The two are never quite the same, and this book was built to stand in the gap between them: between what a farm says it has done and what its instruments can show.

Nine chapters is short for a station that measures its own history in flowerings nine years apart. What the book leaves with the reader, instead of a long chronicle, is a set of instruments and the people who read them: a child who reads drawn shapes whole and cannot read a written word; a chart drawn by an adult whose strokes once turned light into blood; a register with whole years cut out at the binding; a rule made at the wall with no line under it, so that nothing enforces it but the crew's own habit of keeping it.

If there is an argument here, it is about what an answer is. A plant that speaks in leaves cannot be asked what it meant, and a farm that lives on its air cannot wait for certainty. So the characters in this book do the only thing available to them, which is to choose what to measure and then live with the number. Some of them measure blood. One of them measures the water. The Reader measures the shape, and the child's advantage is not innocence, it is attention.

This edition is a working record rather than a monument: three weeks of a flowering and the mornings that came after it, in the order the farm lived them. Read it the way Verrin reads the soil — slowly, and with your hands.